break through to the top in 2020. To visit this area by chopper was not easy either. The chopper would land, the passengers would deplane and the chopper would go back to a helipad at a lower altitude. When it was time to leave, the chopper would return and we would embark, with the rotors still running. The weather had to remain clear throughout this period and it was only after two or three attempts that I was able to get through.

It was not Sikkim or Tawang that I was worried about, though. Sikkim was a small state, well defended by a full Corps and with adequate infrastructure and other resources. The same was the case for the Tawang tract of Arunachal stretching from Me La in the West to Tulung La in the East. It was the area beyond, what in Army parlance is called the Rest of Arunachal Pradesh or RALP, that was the more worrisome. Though it is called RALP, in actuality it is the 'most' of Arunachal Pradesh. Of the 1100-plus-km of the border that it shares with Tibet, almost 900 km is with the RALP, defended by only one Corps. The RALP comprises the valleys of the Subansari, Siyom, Siyang, Dibang and Lohit rivers. Each of the valleys is defended by about a Brigade or so and has to be self-contained in all respects, as there is no interconnectivity between the valleys. There are large unheld areas in between, where there is no deployment. The area is kept under watch through long-range patrols (LRP) which are up to fifteen days' duration. The terrain is treacherous, heavily forested with thick undergrowth, quite unlike the terrain in other areas. Several fast-flowing rivulets have to be negotiated either by wading through them or over rickety foot-bridges. By the end of the LRP, its members become stick thin with their uniforms almost in tatters. Even then, these patrols can only look out for tell-tale signs of incursions but cannot prevent them.

When the Raksha Mantri (RM), Mrs Nirmala Sitharaman, visited, I made it a point to take the RM to Anini, an isolated

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